

LETTUCE *Lactuca sativa*

Freshly picked, homegrown lettuce tastes so much better than supermarket salad greens. There are two main types of lettuce, “loose-leaf” and “hearted”, distinguished by whether or not they form heads. With the correct care and conditions, it is possible to have a continuous crop of lettuce all year round. Getting seeds to germinate can be tricky, but once they have started, lettuces are among the easiest crops to grow.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Lettuces will grow well in most types of moisture-retentive soil, and as long as you provide them with enough water and soil depth, they are suited to growing in containers, too. Site them next to taller crops to provide shade in high summer, since full sun may cause them to bolt.

The best time to plant lettuces is soon after the soil has warmed up in the spring, but if you want a harvest earlier in the summer, sow the seed under cover then transplant outside. For winter harvests, a heated greenhouse is essential in most regions of the United States.

Make shallow furrows and sow at a depth of .5 in (1 cm). Small and medium lettuces will need



Shallow-rooted lettuce will thrive in pots.

around 6–10 in (15–25 cm), and larger, headed lettuces about 14 in (35 cm), since they will need more space to expand.

Sow seed in the afternoon, once the heat of the day has passed, since the cooler temperature increases the chance of seeds germinating. If necessary, thin out the seedlings as they grow, leaving only the strongest ones to develop to full size.